

Report Name

Senegal Ministry of Health_Senegal_2022-23_6-month Report

Fellowship Organization

Senegal Ministry of Health

Fellowship City

Dakar

Fellowship Country

Senegal

Fellowship Start Date

2022-09-01

Fellowship End Date

2023-08-31

Your Fellowship Position and Workplace

What is your fellowship title/role?

Finance Fellow

What are your primary responsibilities?

Supporting financial systems development and grant management processes

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Agree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Yes

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

My supervisor ran a thorough onboarding during the first week covering all key projects and introduced me to the team.

Describe a representative day at work.

Morning emails and team standup. 9am-12pm focused project work and meetings. Lunch with colleagues. 1pm-5pm stakeholder calls and deliverable work.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

45

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

1) Developed a data tracking system for the organization's flagship program. 2) Produced a research brief that was presented to senior leadership.

What is your office environment like?

Open plan office with 20-30 staff. Collaborative and supportive culture.

To whom do you report?

Director of Programs

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

Yes

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year.

- Develop strong project management skills - Build meaningful relationships with local professionals - Complete two high-impact deliverables for the organization - Improve cross-cultural communication skills

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Weekly

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Agree

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I flew from my home country to Dakar. The organization provided travel guidance in advance.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

Carte de Sejour

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

Prefecture in Dakar

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

After arriving

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

No cost

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

Fellow paid initially then reimbursed

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

No

Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

Bring a French speaking colleague to all immigration appointments. Very manageable process.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country?

Arrival was smooth. The organization arranged airport pickup. First week was exciting and overwhelming in a positive way.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Organization provides a housing allowance. I arranged my own accommodation in a safe neighborhood.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Urban

Please describe your living environment

Modern apartment in a safe neighborhood close to the office. Good facilities and reliable utilities.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work?

I use Uber for most journeys and occasionally public transport for shorter distances.

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

The weather in Senegal varies throughout the year. Currently warm with occasional rainfall.

What are the local languages in your community?

Local languages plus English which is widely used in professional settings.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work?

Smart casual for work. Standard casual clothing outside work. Modest dress in traditional settings.

How have you been spending your free time?

Exploring local food and culture, weekend trips to nearby attractions, and building friendships with colleagues and other fellows.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Agree

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

Yes

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

I use Uber rather than walking at night, keep valuables out of sight, and stay aware of my surroundings.

What has been your experience with crime so far?

No direct incidents. I maintain normal urban awareness.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town.

Dakar has a manageable security situation for those who take appropriate precautions. I feel comfortable in my daily movements.

Monthly Budget

Rent

Covered by housing allowance

Transportation

120 USD equivalent per month

Groceries

150 USD equivalent per month

Eating Out

180 USD equivalent per month

Entertainment

100 USD equivalent per month

Reflections and Feedback

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals?

Making good progress on all goals. The professional development and network building goals have been most fulfilling.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

Minor frustrations around work pace and unclear deliverables early on. Overall very satisfied.

How have you dealt with culture shock?

Connecting with local colleagues and being open to new experiences helped enormously. Joining social activities outside work was key.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

The warmth and generosity of people I have met. The sophistication and ambition of the local professional community.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

Adjusting to a new work culture and pace simultaneously with personal adjustment to a new country.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

- Family and close friends - Familiar food from home - Predictable infrastructure

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

- The warmth and hospitality of people - The depth of cultural experience - The sense of purpose and impact in my daily work

Have you had your introductory meeting with your Alumni Mentor?

Yes

How often do you and your mentor check in?

Monthly

The PiAf Fellows Whatsapp Community has helped me build a sense of community with my cohort.

Agree

PiAf's Pre-Departure Orientation was sufficient in preparing me to transition into my fellowship.

Somewhat Agree

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post?

Country specific visa guidance would have been extremely helpful. A guidebook written by past fellows for each country would reduce a lot of uncertainty.

Are you receiving sufficient support, materials and information from the Princeton in Africa office?

Yes, the team has been responsive and supportive throughout.

Programming Ideas

More structured peer connections between fellows in similar countries. A resource library of country specific practical information.